

THE HIJACK DILEMMA

Somali pirates strike at will as the Government dilly-dallies on options to tackle the menace. With the best-equipped navy in the region and considerable experience, it only lacks the willpower to do so.

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

For over a month now, Seema Goyal, a harried homemaker from Dehradun has been running from pillar to post in the national capital. With seven-year-old son Shivansh in tow, she's meeting politicians, ministers and bureaucrats, just about anyone who could expedite the release of her husband Captain Prabhat Kumar Goyal and his 21-member crew aboard the *MV Stolt Valor*, a Hong Kong-registered chemical tanker that was hijacked in the Red Sea by Somali pirates. The Indian Government says the matter is between the ship owners and the pirates. "The crew members were there just to earn their daily bread," says the doughty lady.

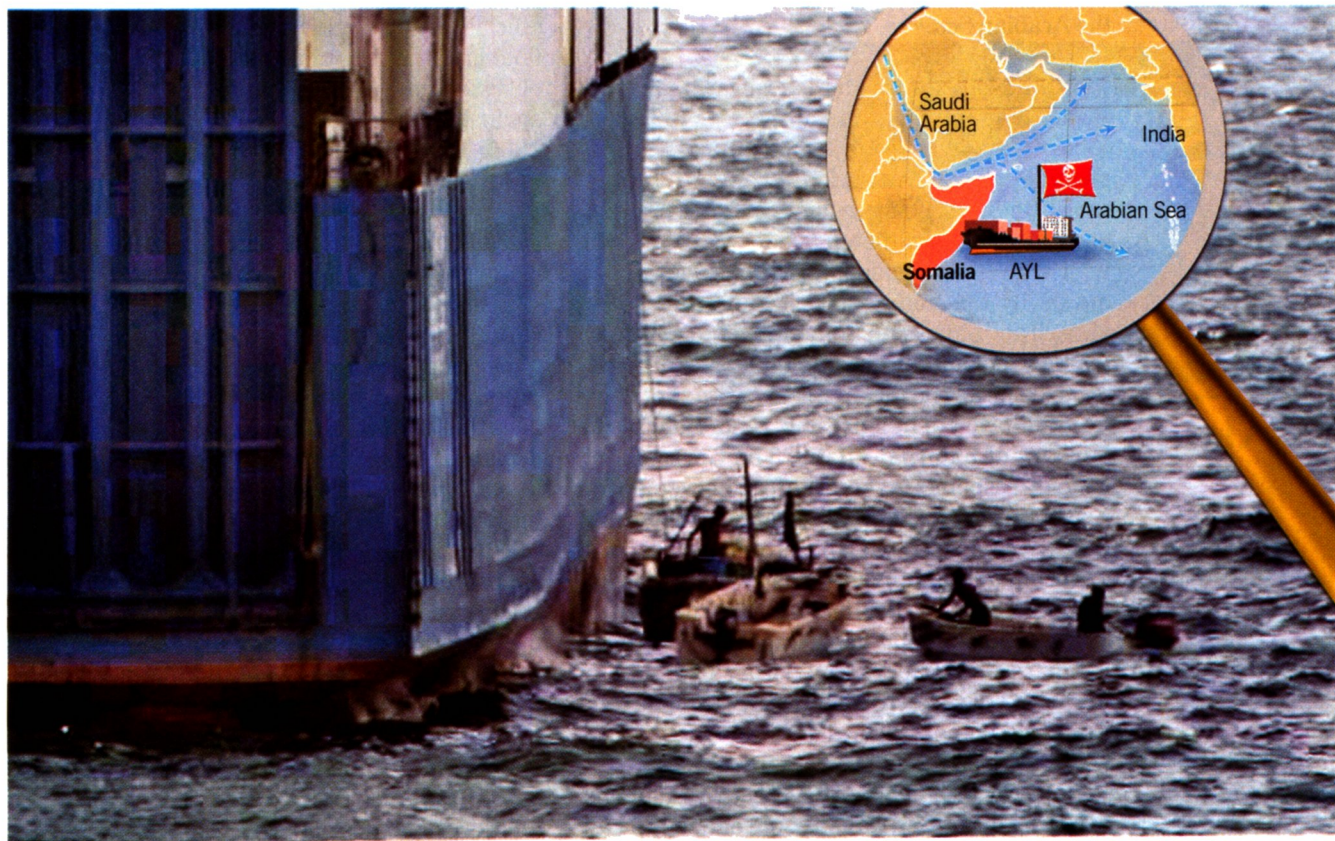
The families of nearly one lakh Indian merchant navy-men—one of the world's largest seafaring communities—could well ask how safe Indian sailors are, who by their sheer numbers run a high risk of being involved in such incidents.

The seas off anarchic Somalia, which has not had a central government since 1991, have

turned into the world's most dangerous waters. Over 60 merchant ships transiting the busy straits of Bab el-Mandeb have been attacked and 30 of them captured by pirates. The *Stolt Valor* was the tenth such incident involving Indian crews. Ships are boarded by the latter-day Red Sea sharks, armed with rocket-propelled grenades and AK-47s, operating speedboats. Ships are held in anchorage off the pirate haven of Ayl in central Somalia until a ransom is paid by the owners. It's a profitable "business" that shipping analysts estimate as worth \$100 million a year. From the glass windows of the bridge of the *Stolt Valor* where Captain Goyal and his frightened crew are held hostage, they can see at least five other hijacked ships, including the Ukrainian *MV Faina* loaded with 33 battle tanks and heavy ordnance.

India, with the world's fifth largest navy having frigates, destroyers, marine commandos, helicopters and giant patrol aircraft like the Tu-142, is the best-equipped in the region to tackle sea scourges like piracy. It also has the best experi-

WATER-BORNE DISEASE: Pirates with the *Faina*; (inset) A map of the area



Photograph by AP PHOTO/US NAVY. Map by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY